

MELONS *Citriullus* spp.

Although melons are close relatives of the cucumber, in cool, temperate regions of the country it is almost inevitable that you will have to grow them under glass, since they need high temperatures and high humidity to thrive. Melons fall into two main categories: sweet melons—such as canteloupes, honeydews, and musk melons—which have dense, juicy flesh, and watermelons, which have crisp, pink, “watery” flesh.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

PLANTING

Sow seed under cover in mid-spring and then plant out in early summer—keep the pots or trays warm, since the seed needs a temperature of at least 60°F (16°C) to germinate. Do not sow too early or the plant may become pot-bound. In warm climates, melons can be grown outdoors, provided that you cover young plants with a cloche or cold frame and site them in a warm and sunny position. Place cloches in position a few weeks prior to planting to warm up the soil. Be vigilant when there is any risk of frost.

Melons prefer a rich, well-draining soil with a neutral pH. Dig in well-rotted manure or compost prior to planting.



Sow three seeds to a pot in mid-spring.

CROP CARE

Keep plants well-watered, but take care to wet the soil and not the stems. If plants are in a cold frame, be sure to open it when they flower to allow for pollination. Fertilize weekly in the blooming period.

HARVESTING AND STORING

Melons should be ready for harvesting in late summer and early fall. Cut the stems with a